

WIDUKIND

My youngest asked me once why we fight Rome instead of joining them.

I did not have a good answer then. I said: because the border will move again. Because the next tribute will be larger. Because they will take everything and call it mercy.

He is twelve now. Or he was, in the autumn.

They took him in the autumn.

I am Widukind. I carried the boar for eleven years. I hung my shield here because I needed somewhere to put it. I could not bury it. I could not burn it. I needed Mars to see it and know I still exist.

If you are holding this shield, Rome sent you here.

Or you came despite Rome.

I want to believe it is the second one.

For Adalbert. For Gerlach.

*For my youngest, whose name I will not write
in case they find him and use it.*